

Curiosity Begets Inquiry and Heart Begets Dedication

Affect is involved in learning as in other domains of human life. Affect is not just emotions but also feelings and attitudes, and it is part of our motivational system. Because of its larger scope, I use the term *affect* instead of *emotion*. Still, emotions make up the core of our affective life in general and are important in our learning. In this chapter, I first introduce the general concept of emotion followed by a description of research on the kinds of emotions and other affects that Western and Asian learners experience. Then I discuss how affects may function in these learners' respective learning.

EMOTION IN GENERAL

Emotions are part of our response system to the environment. They have physiological responses such as heartbeat, perspiration, body temperature (e.g., blushing), and involuntary facial expressions (e.g., crying for sadness and smiling for happiness); feelings and attitudes, however, may not have clear physiological responses. For example, we may feel strange in a place with which we are not familiar, or we may feel generally out of sorts, but such feelings are not necessarily accompanied by notable physiological responses. As for an attitude, we may feel that we are entitled to a higher pay than we actually receive, but have no bodily manifestations of this attitude.¹

An emotion is regarded as both a discrete and an episodic phenomenon. It is discrete because when we experience a particular emotion, such as happiness, our happiness itself is not mixed with sadness or any other unrelated emotion, despite the fact that our happiness may be of a more or less subtle kind such as elation or relief. Sometimes we do realize that we have mixed emotions; for example, a warrior may win a great battle and feel

triumphant and in the same second he may feel sadness for the loss of his comrades. However, this so-called mixed emotion does not mean that our discrete emotions of triumphant happiness and the sadness for the fallen are truly mixed. Quite the contrary, our happiness in this instance has an entirely different cause, namely winning. Our sadness has a different cause, namely our consideration for the dead and wounded. Therefore, we still experience our happiness first in the temporal sequence and our sadness later, no matter how closely the second emotion may follow the first one. The two emotions are thus still discrete.²

Emotions are also episodic because we experience our emotions temporally. Simply put, emotions come and go. Ross Buck notes that we tend to notice our emotions (and are often noticed by others around us) when they become relatively strong even though our emotional system is always turned on under normal circumstances.³ Thus, any emotional episode can be seen as having three basic components that unfold in time: a cause or antecedence, a response/reaction, and coping afterward.⁴ Nico Frijda advanced this basic understanding of emotions into a sequence of seven components, specifying how each phase happens: (1) *antecedent events* that generate emotions – for example, an event, a personal act (e.g., tasting good food), social interaction, or sometimes even a recollection or an image in our head can trigger an emotion in us; (2) *event coding* during which one characterizes the event in reference to event types as recognized by one's culture (e.g., a kind gesture versus an insult); (3) *appraisal* in which one evaluates the implications of the event to the self (e.g., “am I responsible?”); (4) *physiological reaction patterns* where a given emotion is linked to a set of autonomic reactions (e.g., shame leads to blushing and looking away); (5) *action readiness* where the person selects the next course of actions from a repertoire of possible actions (e.g., fear prompts the impulse to run away); (6) *emotional behavior* where one takes action (e.g., actual running away in fear); and finally (7) *regulation* where the person selects ways to deal with the emotion and the action taken (e.g., staying engaged with the event when feeling happy).⁵

Traditionally, affect is contrasted with cognition as two opposite ends in psychological research. However, recent research shows that affect and cognition are inseparable in human functioning. In order for us to experience any emotion, we use our mind to appraise the event to determine its relevance and importance to ourselves before our emotions are generated. In fact, Frijda's theory is called “appraisal theory” because it emphasizes how our mind perceives preceding causes, how we code such events and appraise them to determine to personal significance to ourselves before our

emotions can be activated. Similarly, when we are engaged in mental work, our affective system is turned on to generate motivation for the task at hand if we are to sustain our engagement.⁶

Positive and Negative Affect in Learning

Affect in learning, like affect in general, has two valences: positive and negative. Because both affect and learning are temporal processes, it is helpful to discuss affect in learning as segmented in three phases that correspond to the three phases of emotion unfolding: prior to learning, during learning, and after learning. Each of these phases can have positive or negative affect.

We feel positive affect in learning when we are interested, curious, wondering about the world, and desiring to know/understand more. Prior to learning, we may feel hopeful, excited, and uplifted about the idea that we can learn new things.⁷ Such positive affect motivates us to take action to engage in the actual learning, such as reading about the topic, seeking more information, and trying things. When we succeed in our effort, we may feel encouraged by, satisfied with, and proud of our learning. As a result, we are likely to seek such learning again.

On the other hand, we may experience negative affect if we are not interested and curious about the material, but rather are forced to learn by someone else. We may feel unmotivated and even anxious and dreadful about learning a particular piece of knowledge/skill. For example, if a person desires to learn how to swim but fails to learn the skill, that person's anticipatory excitement may diminish quickly, and he or she may feel lack of self-confidence. At this point, the person may either give up or attempt to try again. But if he or she is forced to learn swimming again against his or her will, the person may become fearful of it. Repeated failure may result in lower self-confidence, and depending on the importance of learning attached to the self, the person may develop the more global negative affect of low self-estimate or temporary frustration. Whenever we have such learning experiences, we are likely to have negative affect and consequently try to avoid such learning.

CULTURAL VARIATION IN LEARNING-RELATED AFFECT

Although there are common human affective responses to learning, culture, as it turns out, is a source of significant variations in the affect we experience in learning. Batjia Mesquita and Frijda maintain that culture

is involved in all the seven phases of an emotion episode, because human emotional experience is a result of the combination of autonomic responses and regulated responses according to specific cultural models.⁸ As discussed in [Chapter 4](#), Robert Levy studied Tahitians and found that some emotions in that culture were elaborated and fully expressed whereas others were almost absent. Anger in Tahitian culture is the former and sadness is the latter, resulting from the norms concerning the function of these emotions in Tahitian social life. Levy proposed the terms *hypercognized* versus *hypocognized* emotions to capture culturally shaped emotional experiences.⁹ Drawing on this framework, Mesquita argues that cultures can differ in the *frequency* of appraisals, action readiness, expression and behavior, and regulatory processes. Although humans across cultures may have similar physiological responses to a given emotion, such as smiling while happy, the high or low frequencies of the culturally framed processes indicate consistency or inconsistency with a given cultural model.¹⁰ In other words, if pride in learning achievement is emphasized in a culture, the learners will likely feel pride, express it, and behave accordingly. If pride in learning is devalued in another culture, then we can expect to encounter a less frequent occurrence of pride in learning.

Learning-Related Affect in Western Learners

In order to proceed with learning-related affect in both Western and Asian learners, I follow the three distinct phases of prior to, during, and post-learning rather than Frijda's seven steps in the process of emotion activation. I do so because many affects in learning may not be clearly emotional in the strict sense, even though they overlap with emotions, as noted earlier. In addition, discussing the three-phase learning-related affect corresponds well with the process of our learning behavior and activities. However, it is also important to point out that any affect that is associated with a given phase of the learning process is not truly isolated, even though each emotion is discrete. Because learning (formal or informal) is an integral part of continuous human existence, a particular affective response at the moment may have been formed and strengthened with many repeated prior experiences. There is, thus, likely a loop of learning and feeling following each other and intertwined with each other. One's affective reaction to a particular outcome of learning may have everything to do with how that person may feel toward the next learning task. Therefore, the following discussions of prior to, during, and post-learning are not treated as separate phases per se but as a heuristic strategy to present research on learning-related affects.

Prior to Learning

Most research that deals with learning-related affect in Western learners is found in the large research body of achievement motivation. This research focuses on what motivates people for a particular achievement task, such as completing an anagram or a math problem in experimental situations. It is assumed that people's achievement motivation is a basic human need, and their beliefs about achievement are formed through their repeated life experiences with achievement outcomes. Accordingly, a person who faces any given achievement situation brings with him- or herself a set of prior beliefs and related evaluations that will influence the person's affective reactions to the task and outcome. In the 1960s, Western researchers discovered that people facing achievement tasks have two motives: the need to achieve success and the desire to avoid failure. Specific affects were involved in these expectations. For the need to achieve, the person expects to succeed and therefore to feel proud. This anticipated emotion motivates the person to take on the task. But if the person expects to fail, he/she is likely to anticipate shame, and the resultant action is to avoid the task (failure).¹¹

At the core of achievement motivation research is the distinction of intrinsic versus extrinsic motivation. People experience intrinsic motivation when they desire activities and make efforts that are an end unto themselves rather than a means to some other goals. For example, we are intrinsically motivated when we enjoy reading a good book, but we are extrinsically motivated to go to a job that we would rather not do but we must do because we need the money. Needless to say, intrinsic motivation in learning is prized in the West and extrinsic motivation is shunned.

In general, researchers recognize three main areas that generate intrinsic motivation. The first is the affect of curiosity, and curiosity-based motivation is intrinsic by nature. Human beings are assumed to be naturally curious about novel events and activities that are incongruent with their expectations. As noted in [Chapter 4](#), when learners are curious about a given topic, they tend to be motivated to seek such knowledge in order to satisfy their curiosity.¹² Again, curiosity is a highly valued trait in any learner in the West.

A related affect is interest. Based on research, interest could be similar to curiosity. For example, a student may be interested in black holes and would like to learn more about them. If the student's interest is in understanding black holes themselves rather than in the ability to impress people with his or her knowledge, then the student's interest is intrinsic. However, interest may be geared toward extrinsic purposes. For example, a person sitting in a doctor's waiting room happens to spot a magazine article about how a

person can get an unconventional, high-paying job. Intrigued, this person picks up the magazine and reads the article, and afterward continues to seek additional information about this new job.¹³ Although the person displays interest, this type of interest may not be intrinsic because it is serving another end (i.e., not the job itself, but the higher paycheck it offers). Thus, curiosity is a more pure form of intrinsic motivation, whereas interest by itself may not be exclusively intrinsic, depending on the end that a given interest serves.

The second form of intrinsic motivation comes from the observation that human beings have innate tendencies to seek opportunities to develop competence; therefore, they are intrinsically motivated to achieve. Achievement is testimony to our competence. Being competent, then, is not motivated by external rewards, although such rewards do frequently follow competent people. Even very young children display excitement about opportunities to develop and display their competence. For example, children often announce eagerly, “I want to kick the ball!” and proudly, “I can write my name!”

The best-known research on intrinsic versus extrinsic motivation emphasizes the notion that human beings have a natural need to feel autonomous and self-determining. Self-chosen tasks make people feel that they are in control of their own activities and work as directed by their own volition instead of by external rewards or avoidance of punishment. Research shows that when Western students can choose their own learning tasks – that is, when they have autonomy in learning – they feel motivated, happy, energetic, and excited in anticipation of success and enjoyment.¹⁴

An important part of research on achievement motivation is the notion of *self-efficacy* that has been studied extensively. Albert Bandura is the main researcher and theorist on this topic. The thrust of Bandura’s theory is his focus on individuals’ personal evaluation of their performance capabilities on a given task, not on their general sense of ability or their actual capability of succeeding. Bandura stresses that if a person lacks the skill, that person is motivated toward getting the skill.¹⁵ Therefore, feeling efficacious moves people toward learning and mastery.

During Learning

Affect plays a key role in whether a person will continue learning once started. Several lines of research provide clues to how affect functions during learning. Carole Dweck’s early research examined the notion of *learned helplessness* in learners. In her study, when children believed that they lacked the ability to succeed in a task, they gave up easily in the face of challenging

tasks. Those who believed that they could increase their ability by learning persisted even when they failed. The former group of children exhibited low self-esteem and fear of failure, which was captured with the general notion of learned helplessness. But the latter group of children showed resilience and tenacity in the face of setbacks. These observations led Dweck to develop the theory of entity versus incremental intelligence. Accordingly, the entity-minded learners view intelligence as something that one either has or does not have. In contrast, the increment-oriented learners view intelligence as something that they can increase with learning and mastery.¹⁶

The decade-long research in this area shows that Western learners in general are particularly sensitive to the feedback on their ongoing learning and performance, which affects whether they will continue their effort. Two kinds of information are especially important. First, learners need the learning information that is relevant to the specific task because it is needed in order to understand the problem or issue at hand.¹⁷ Second, they need feedback that informs them that they are doing well. However, if the feedback tells them that they are not doing well, they are likely to feel less motivated and ultimately may even give up.¹⁸ This general pattern of Western learners' motivation in learning as a need to receive ongoing *positive* feedback corresponds to the general emphasis on self-esteem in the West and a deeper sense that the self is more or less fixed, and thus needs ongoing affirmation.¹⁹ Learners, particularly young children, are believed to be in need of high self-esteem to facilitate learning. Parental and teacher praise is therefore widely used as a strategy to keep children motivated.²⁰

The most significant research on affect during learning engagement was done by Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi and associates.²¹ Their research began in the 1970s with an innovative empirical approach called "experience sampling method." The research participants were given a beeper and a booklet containing questions about where the person was, what the person was doing, what emotions they were feeling (both positive and negative), and if the person would rather be somewhere else or rather be doing something else. The beeper was programmed to beep randomly during the day and evenings. When the beeper beeped, the participant was asked to answer the questions in the booklet. Csikszentmihalyi's team collected a large body of such daily experiences from students, particularly adolescents.

They discovered a significant psychological phenomenon, which Csikszentmihalyi termed *flow*. Flow is a state of which any human being is capable. It is a state of human personal engagement in an activity, be it work, learning, performance, or just playing. Four key factors are at play, with two input factors and two resultant affective responses. The two input

factors are one's skill and the task that one is tackling/performing. If one's skill exceeds that demanded by the task, such as a skilled violin virtuoso being asked to play a beginner piece, the person is likely to feel bored, which is one affective response. Although boredom is common in our daily lives, it is a state that most human beings would rather avoid. However, if the task's skill demand exceeds one's current skill level, such as a beginner violin learner being asked to perform a complicated piece of music, that person is likely to experience anxiety, which is the second affective response. Based on Csikszentmihalyi's extensive data, the best state is when one's skill matches that demanded by the task. In this situation, the person feels neither boredom nor anxiety. Instead, the person feels happy, lost in the task, enjoying it, frequently oblivious to time passage, and not self-conscious of his or her performance. This very state is the flow state.

What Csikszentmihalyi's research has revealed is intrinsic motivation at its best. Other related research on Western children in learning also supports the view that when learners can choose their own learning tasks and control their own learning directions and pace – that is, have a sense of autonomy – they enjoy the task more and do actually achieve better learning results.²² Learners are thus likely to have stronger positive feelings about their learning and seek ways to engage in such learning further.

Post-Learning

Much research on achievement-related affect has been done to assess how people respond to their performance on tasks – that is, after learning has occurred. Following Atkinson's initial finding that affect is generated with regard to expectation of pride for success and fear of failure, researchers examined several related areas and provided more sophisticated views of the processes. Julian Rotter proposed a theory on people's *locus of control*, positing that individuals' expectations of success or failure depend on whether they perceive causes of success or failure to be internally or externally located.²³ Thus, if a person believes that his or her ability is the cause of his or her success, and given that ability is an internal attribute, that person will be more confident that he or she will succeed in the task. By contrast, if a person believes that luck will determine the outcome, then given that luck lies outside the person's ability to control, he or she will expect a low certainty of success. A person's sense of locus of control is therefore a key determinant to how he or she feels about an achievement outcome.

As it turned out, there was more to how Western students' expectation of success and failure operates. Bernard Weiner advanced Rotter's basic formulation into a new theory called *attribution theory*.²⁴ Weiner posited that

human beings are naturally inclined to search for a causal understanding of events, thus making causal attributions, especially about events that are important to them (e.g., an academic performance). Such causal attributions in turn influence people's behavior and emotional reactions in later achievement situations. The theory specifies three factors and their interactions: *locus*, *stability*, and *control*. Locus here refers to where individuals believe the cause of their achievement outcome is located, again either the internal or the external being the two possible *sources*. Stability addresses the individual's belief in the *duration* of the cause, which is defined as either stable or unstable. Finally, control, originally within the concept of locus in Rotter's conception, now denotes only the *degree* of control the person perceives to have over the cause, which is postulated to be either controllable or uncontrollable. Using these factors, researchers can analyze important concepts in achievement motivation. For example, ability and effort, the two most frequently identified attributions, were now found to differ in their stability and controllability in addition to their common internal source. Whereas effort is usually perceived as controllable, it is often unstable from task to task. However, ability, viewed as a capacity, is generally perceived as a stable but relatively uncontrollable cause.

Weiner's theory has generated research that documents the specific affects associated with these three attributional factors. Accordingly, individuals reported feeling surprised when attributing their success or failure to luck, and guilty when attributing their failure to lack of effort. Gratitude is felt for receiving others' help. Pride and shame occur only in attribution to internal causes. Whereas individuals feel proud when ascribing their success to their ability and hard work, they feel shame when attributing their failure to lack of effort. Furthermore, pride is more likely to be experienced when success is believed to be a result of ability or hard work rather than of receiving help from others.²⁵

Parallel to the attribution theory is another theory, the *self-worth* theory, that has important affective implications. Advanced by Covington and associates, this theory argues that human beings have the need to perceive competence as their self-worth – that is, the individual's appraisal of his or her own value. As a natural consequence, individuals are assumed to strive to protect their sense of self-worth when they feel it is threatened, for example by school failure.²⁶ Studies based on this theory concentrated on strategies individuals use to maintain their self-worth. In support of the attribution theory, research based on the self-worth theory also found that individuals took personal credit (usually attributing it to their ability) for their successes and attributed failures to external causes such as

difficulty of task. Moreover, individuals will try to avoid negative implications of failure resulting from low ability by minimizing participation in performance activities.²⁷ Fearing revealing low ability, many students simply do not try, especially when faced with less challenging tasks (moderate difficulty), because failure with no effort could not be ascertained to result from lack of ability, thereby keeping their self-worth intact. Most striking is the analysis of effort likened to a “double-edged sword” by Covington and Omelich.²⁸ When they anticipate a threat of revealing their low ability associated with failure despite their high effort, students are unwilling to try, even if it means subjecting themselves to reprimand for not trying. Many more strategies for not trying have been identified, ranging from publicly downgrading the importance of studying, to using excuses for not trying, to choosing unattainable goals (guaranteed failure but no implication of low ability).

My own research on Western model learners indicated affects mentioned by a majority (62 percent) of the participants for being knowledgeable are happiness, joy, satisfaction, excitement, and fulfillment. Pride was the second most frequently mentioned emotion (53 percent). However, when not being knowledgeable, the set of affects most frequently mentioned by participants (47 percent) included frustration, discouragement, disappointment, and general unhappiness. Finally, 19 percent of these respondents mentioned feeling inferiority, low self-esteem, shame, embarrassment, humiliation, guilt, and low self-worth.²⁹

The aforementioned research provides a consistent picture of a specific set of affects that Western learners experience in the learning process. Their curiosity and interest direct them to explore the world with personal initiative and autonomy. Such motivation is intrinsic by nature and generates excitement, enjoyment, and fun within the individual learner. For other tasks that are not necessarily self-generated and driven by curiosity/interest (e.g., typical school learning tasks that are more imposed by the social world), Western learners are likely to feel motivated if they expect a positive outcome of an upcoming achievement/learning task. The specific affect is pride as well as other related positive feelings such as happiness. During learning, learners are fine-tuned to the ongoing feedback of their own task performance. If they continue to do well, they are likely to be more motivated in the task engagement, continuing their effort. However, if the feedback is not positive, learners may become frustrated and discouraged, causing their effort to diminish, eventually causing them to give up. It appears that their afterthought – that is, determining the causes of their performance – may be a key factor in what kind of affect they feel vis-à-vis

a given outcome. When attributing success to one's internal qualities such as high ability, the learner is likely to feel proud of him- or herself. When attributing failure to one's internal quality, the learner is likely to feel devastated (shame and low self-esteem) because it is a painful realization of a negative quality of the seemingly unalterable self. Although Western learners may also attribute their success to their effort, thereby feeling proud of themselves, they are likely to feel more proud and more self-worth with high ability. If an achievement situation is about protecting the self-worth, ability matters more than effort. Thus, Western learners' affects are part and parcel of their learning beliefs, and such affect-laden beliefs are formed in the loop of prior to, during, and post-learning over time.

Learning-Related Affect in Chinese/East Asian Learners

Unlike Western learning affect, Chinese/East Asian learning affect is largely based on personal conviction, not on personal curiosity about, interest in, or enjoyment of a particular subject of study or activity. It is conviction-based because of its moral and virtue focus as noted in previous chapters. However, just because it is conviction-based does not mean that Chinese/East Asian learners do not have very deep and powerful affects that propel their learning.

Prior to Learning

Because learning in Chinese/East Asian world is geared toward a life-long process of self-transformation, people's learning affect is also oriented toward this long-term goal rather than specific tasks that can change from situation to situation. As noted in [Chapter 3](#), the Chinese cultural learning model indicates that dedication and commitment, rather than personal curiosity about, interest in, and fun with a specific subject, are the general affective focus. Because of this life-orientation, "prior to learning" as a concept and empirical strategy to segment the learning process does not quite apply to Chinese learners in the strict sense. Nevertheless, children must be brought on this learning path; therefore, there must be a beginning of the process, and there is one.

As found in my model learner study (see [Chapter 3](#)), the starting point for Chinese people's learning affect is the so-called establishing one's will (*lizhi*, 立志), a commitment to learning. Traditionally, when children entered the age of "understanding things" (*dongshi*, 懂事) around age six or seven, they were deemed cognitively and socially capable of engaging in dedicated studies.³⁰ To the extent that it could afford formal learning, a family usually

found a private tutor in the local town, who taught Confucian texts to children, and held a ceremony to officially “acknowledge the teacher” (*baishi*, 拜師). Whether or not the child himself liked this parent-decided path and commitment was unimportant because every child (i.e., every male child throughout most of Chinese history, but now all children) has to learn to self-perfect in the Confucian learning tradition. Every effort was made to guide the child to understand this learning path, and backing out of this path was not an option. Some children never got very far on this path, but many did. Tutors and families continued to work with children so that the latter would embrace learning with their whole heart and mind. When the moment came, the child would “establish his will.” There was no official rite for this moment of intellectual enlightenment, but it was still a personal coming to terms with learning for life. The child might share his will with family and friends, which served as a process of witnessing the commitment. The psychological function is very similar to a Western child who knew early on that he wanted to be, for example, a veterinarian and moved on to pursue that career for life. The difference lies in that the Western child’s “will” or volition is purely based on his or her personal curiosity, interest, and sentiment; the family may have very little to do with what he might pursue for life. In the Chinese case, family was the key force for putting the child on the path in the first place.³¹

This long tradition of establishing one’s will remains strong in the present-day Chinese societies. Families, schools, and society at large make a concerted effort to emphasize the importance of establishing one’s will. State media and school discourse are replete with ongoing discussions about how children need to have a long-term purpose for learning so that they can contribute to society. There has been much research converging on the consistent finding that Chinese/East Asian parents monitor their children’s learning much more intensively and enroll them in extra learning more frequently relative to other cultural groups.³² This general research finding corresponds quite well with the very tradition that on the surface may have been jettisoned but deep down still operates strongly, albeit in modern forms (e.g., learning extracurricular artistic skills that require much dedication and commitment).

While the child is socialized toward establishing his/her will, parents and teachers on the one hand and the learner him- or herself on the other use this long-term goal as the motivator for each concrete learning activity. In my study on model learners, participants described how these learners felt uplifted, energized, empowered, and deeply grounded to pursue learning goals, regardless of how uninteresting a given subject was and regardless

of how difficult the particular piece of knowledge a learner had to acquire. They used terms such as *love*, *passion*, and *thirst* to describe the general affect of learning motivation based on an established will.

My lexicon study also revealed a number of affect terms that indicate this type of orientation: *make a firm resolution to study* (發奮讀書); *if you don't learn when you are young, what will you do when you are old?* (幼不學, 老何為?); *devote oneself to studying* (潛心學習); *the best approach to learning is single-hearted devotion* (學貴以專); *desire to seek knowledge* (求知欲); *eager to learn* (好學); and *heart and mind for wanting to learn* (好學心).³³ These terms describe a general affective orientation toward learning in the long run rather than for specific learning tasks. In this regard, it is in sharp contrast to Western learners who may project success or failure on a particular achievement outcome and related affect. Chinese learners appear to orient themselves toward a longer and larger goal with commitment and devotion. As a result, the specific learning tasks and achievement outcomes may be less of the focus in their affect prior to learning any particular skill.

During Learning

Given their long-term goals, Chinese/East Asian learners may experience different affect during learning than their Western peers. My lexicon study yielded a number of terms that give some clues of their affect: *having studied, to then repeatedly apply what you have learned – is this not a source of pleasure* (Confucius)? (學而時習之, 不亦說乎?); *put one's heart into one's study* (用心讀書); *study as if thirsting or hungering* (如飢似渴地學習); and (so absorbed as to) *forget food and sleep* (廢寢忘食). Pursuing life-long learning to morally transform oneself with a personal commitment was conceived of as a pleasure by Confucius; it should not be a dread. This phrase by Confucius is in fact the very first question recorded in the *Analects*, rhetorical in nature but inviting his students to think about the affect that such learning brings. Throughout Chinese history, learning/studying has been viewed as a serious personal endeavor, as discussed in previous chapters. Therefore, having a will established, it is only natural to study wholeheartedly (as a manifestation of sincerity). Then delving deeply into one's learning is likened to such a desire as feeling thirsty and hungry. The last phrase is reminiscent of Csikszentmihalyi's affective state of flow where the learner is so engrossed in study as to forget food and sleep (not even conscious of one's own physical needs). Indeed, many participants in my model learner study used these expressions to describe their model learners in the process of learning.

Empirical research on the actual affective experience during learning among East Asian learners is scant. But there are a few studies that shed some light on that experience. To begin with, a study completed most recently examined what types of goals motivated East Asian and European-American college students who were not interested in math. The researcher provided three types of goals: proximal (short-term, relevant to the learning task at hand), distal (long-term goals, not immediately relevant to the learning task at hand, e.g., career),³⁴ and self-discovered goals (regardless of proximal and distal reference). It was found that European-American students' motivation did not increase when they were told (therefore not self-chosen but externally provided) about the importance of a new math technique. In comparison, East Asian students worked harder and showed more interest in the new technique after being told that it could help them reach their distal goals. Moreover, when proximal and distal goals were examined side by side, it was found that European-American students were more motivated when told that learning the math technique could help them reach their proximal goals (e.g., tips for calculating math problems quickly). But East Asian students again showed higher interest and worked harder when they were told that the new technique could help them reach their distal goals in life.³⁵

My own research on model learners also indicated that they did not focus on affect such as curiosity, interest, enjoyment, and fun – that is, the traditionally defined intrinsic motivation. Instead, they experienced personal striving, charging up to anticipated difficulties (enduring hardship), overcoming their natural tendency to relax, or to use their own term, “to be lazy” – in other words, challenging themselves. Two sets of open-ended responses were particularly revealing. The first contained responses to the question “How would your model learner learn if he/she has made great efforts but still couldn’t learn?” Recall that research on Western learners shows that their continuous motivation is contingent on the ongoing feedback on how well they are doing. If the feedback is positive – that is, confirming the positive and able self – they are more likely to continue. In contrast, Japanese students persisted longer after being told that they did not do well.³⁶ Similar to Japanese responses, 50 percent of the Chinese participants in my study wrote “change study methods.” Other statements were “persist” (32 percent) and “humbly ask others to teach oneself” (30 percent). The second set of responses was to the question “How would your model learner learn if he/she found a subject uninteresting or even boring?” Sixty percent of the participants wrote “force oneself to persist.” The remaining expressions were “force oneself to persist if the knowledge is

deemed important/useful” (28 percent) and “finding ways to make oneself interested” (24 percent).

Juxtaposing the two sets of responses of the two cultural groups, it seems that Chinese learners did indeed not focus on the negative emotions (no participants mentioned them regarding the first question, whereas 42 percent of European-American participants spontaneously did so). But half of the Chinese participants believed that the learner who could not learn despite great efforts will succeed with different methods. Only 13 percent indicated that the learner should give up (compared to 42 percent European-American respondents). Similarly, regarding the boredom question, the majority of Chinese participants wrote “forcing oneself to persist” (強迫自己學) as an antidote to combat boredom. Except one, no other European-American respondents used the language “force oneself to learn” to describe their model learners. Moreover, fewer Chinese participants offered study with less enthusiasm (17 percent) and not pursuing the subject anymore (17 percent) as solutions to the boredom problem (compared to 32 percent and 26 percent, respectively, by their European-American peers). European-American participants repeatedly expressed the belief that a learner cannot learn well without interest and should not have to spend time and energy learning things that he or she finds boring. Examples of actual responses are: “you have to follow your interest, and you can only learn well when the interest is there”; “he learns to enjoy”; and “the acquisition of knowledge must be an interesting and fulfilling process for him to want to pursue it.” Such comments were far less frequent among Chinese participants.

To examine to what extent the ideal learner image is reflected in ordinary Chinese learners, I conducted another study on how Chinese adolescents viewed themselves in the learning process by asking them to complete ten identical sentences that began with “In learning, I ...”³⁷ A total of 259 adolescents (twelve to nineteen years of age) from two large regions of China gave open-ended responses. The most frequent self-descriptions were the various learning virtues. In comparison, there were few references to positive emotions such as enjoyment and excitement or negative emotions such as frustration and disappointment, as well as interest/disinterest, and confidence/lack of it. It seems clear that affect, either positive or negative, does not play a strong role in their views of themselves as learners.

In support of this basic finding on affective orientation of Chinese learner, Hsin Mei Huang provides a telling report on how children in Taiwan find the infamous “cram schools” actually motivating, beyond their parents’ desire to continue their attendance.³⁸ For those who are unfamiliar with this unique Asian schooling phenomenon, “cram schools” are common in East

Asian countries like Taiwan, Japan, Korea, Hong Kong, China, Singapore, and Vietnam. They are private enterprises that offer additional academic and extracurricular enrichment programs to school-aged children for a fee, and according to popular belief, all are built to feed the academic pressure and hype in those countries (not surprisingly, such schools also exist in the American cities where large Asian populations reside³⁹).

There are many critics of this Asian educational phenomenon, both within and outside Asia. They condemn these schools as a consequence of the idea of “examination hell” and point out that children go to regular school for the day and then have to attend extra school afterward. Their leisure and other meaningful, fun childhood activities are stolen, according to popular discourse.⁴⁰ As a response to such criticisms, Asian countries have issued policies to reduce a six-day school week to a five-day school week and to scale back homework assignments in order to allow children to have a childhood. Even the English term *cram school* for a rather neutral native term *Buxiban* (tutoring or supplementary classes, 補習班) in Chinese has been accepted as the official translation. The ease of Asian scholars’ usage of the English term (without quotation marks) also shows the Asian acceptance of the disapproval and ridicule connoted in the term “cram.” As such, it does not require a stretch of imagination to assume that Asian children should hate “cram schools.” But research, surprisingly, indicates otherwise.

Despite mounting criticisms, “cram schools” continue to boom and flourish. Huang’s research investigated reasons given by parents as well as children. In Taiwan, half of all school-aged children – a very high number – attend “cram schools.” From parents’ perspective, “cram schools” help prevent juvenile delinquency, enable children to put their precious time in young age to learning more, and provide a chance to make up for children’s inadequacies in their formal schooling so as to increase their chances of getting into better schools. This is predicated on the belief that learning well in school is the most important task for children. It is not surprising that these are parents’ reasons for sending their children to “cram school.” What is counterintuitive is that the children themselves have positive things to say about their “cram schools.” Children appear to accept the fact that there is widespread peer pressure to achieve better for everyone. High academic achievers are liked and accepted more by peers, and these children are not labeled as nerds as they may be in the United States and other Western societies. (see focused discussion on this topic in Chapter 6) By contrast, poor academic achievement can lead to peer rejection. Thus, even though children may not like the fact that they have to go to more school, they view such extra learning as important and necessary.

They therefore are motivated to continue “cram school” and try their best there.

Research on Japanese adolescents attending their “cram schools” (*Juku*, 塾) and extracurricular training schools (*Bukatsu*, 活部) shows the same pattern. Although youth did not have very positive emotions to report during these school hours, they nevertheless indicated that they wanted to go to *Juku* and to train hard at *Bukatsu*.⁴¹ Such unique extracurricular activity reflects their culture’s value of the concept *gambaru*, a value of the intrinsic benefits of persistence, which the Japanese culture desires in their children (as noted in [Chapter 3](#)).⁴² Another related study also showed that Vietnamese students reported higher motivation for study than their German peers, despite their acknowledged higher pressure to study hard from home.

Taken together, the previously reviewed research indicates two important differences in affect during learning between the two cultural groups. First, it provides support for the idea that the East Asian learners’ motivation may not be anchored in the curiosity about and interest in the specific learning task at hand – that is, in the self-based, task-specific affect. Neither do they seek enjoyment and fun as a *primary condition* under which to engage in learning. As noted previously, learning in Confucian heritage cultures is not conceptualized as a fun and purely enjoyable process, but one that is wrought with hardship that must be overcome. The Confucian conceptualization of moral self-perfection as a source of pleasure is not the kind learners may experience spontaneously, but one that comes only after a person has done much seeking and contemplation. It is a path that one walks willingly, knowing that it requires determination, commitment, and endurance of hardship, and with such personal dedication and enlightenment one may achieve a further goal: the transformation of the pain of self-exertion into a pleasure.

Thus, East Asian learning-related affect seems to be based more on the conviction and commitment to life-long goals. The specific learning tasks that may fluctuate from moment to moment may not impact (excite or frustrate) the East Asian learners as strongly as they sometimes do their Western peers. Instead, their self-striving and work toward longer-term goals may serve to tone down the excessively positive or negative emotions (which may well be perceived as disturbances and diversions from their ultimate goals).⁴³ Their attention is on how to master the current learning in order to move forward toward their longer-term goals. In other words, their overall emphasis on persistence may result in different affect than Western learners’ experiences of curiosity, interest, fun, and intrinsic enjoyment in learning, as found by research.

Researchers’ understanding of this tendency of East Asian learners received further confirmation in a recent study conducted by Hsiao d’Ailly,

who used Western measures of autonomy and intrinsic motivation to study schoolchildren in Taiwan.⁴⁴ Although these measures were found to have validity and reliability, parental involvement and support of autonomy (encouraging their children to exercise autonomy) as well as teachers' modeling and instruction regarding autonomy (encouraging it or being more controlling toward children) did not make a difference in children's intrinsic motivation. Neither did children's level of autonomy impact how much effort they made in their studies. The most interesting finding in this research was that when children's own sense of control regarding their own ability and learning strategy was put aside, their so-called external motivation, surprisingly, had a positive effect on their achievement. The author thus concluded that

for children in Taiwan, interest and fun ... may not be as strong a motivator for hard work as rules (external) and values [for learning].... Although ... children [may be] motivated by intrinsic interest in their learning, it is also logical to infer that students with a higher sense of autonomy, who study mainly for fun and interest and do not yield much to external pressures, are more likely to decide not to study when they cannot find fun and interest in their learning.

Another conclusion one may draw is that it may not matter to East Asian students where the source of their motivation stems from. In other words, the dichotomy of intrinsic versus extrinsic motivation may not be drawn as sharply among East Asian learners as among their Western peers. As noted in [Chapter 3](#), research conducted by Iyengar and Lepper as well as by Xuehua Bao and Shui-fong Lam showed clearly that Asian-American children learned equally well and enjoyed their learning when their learning task was chosen by the trusted members of their social world (i.e., in good relationships), but European-American children learned better and enjoyed the learning when they themselves chose their tasks.⁴⁵ This is to say that the external world may give East Asian learners a stronger motivation and affect for learning than their Western peers. However, it may not be appropriate to assume that socially shaped motivation is the same as extrinsic motivation, as Maarten Vansteenkiste and associates have convincingly argued.⁴⁶ Children accepting parental and teacher's guidance on learning for their ultimate moral self-perfection, particularly after they themselves have established their will, is unlikely to be extrinsic because moral and virtue goals are ends in themselves.

Perhaps defining intrinsic motivation solely as interest and fun (which is sometimes couched as the best type of motivation there is in the whole

human world) may need rethinking. Consider the case of the dedication and passion that deeply spiritual and religious people display in pursuing their goals. I would argue that this type of motivation is more intrinsic than the interest and fun-based intrinsic motivation because the latter is subject to situational, task, and mood changes, and therefore can be short-lived. A short-lived motivation, no matter how intrinsic, is not as desirable as a long-lasting and passionate intrinsic motivation for learning. For example, a child may find a particular book fun, but he or she may not find many other books fun, and hence may lose interest in reading these other books. But a person who is determined to read as many books as possible because he or she finds learning through books important and fulfilling for life has a passionate conviction about reading books for life. The kind of conviction and passion at which Confucian learning aims is the latter, not the former. And East Asian cultures believe that children have a better chance of developing long-term passionate motivation with the concerted social support from families, schools, and communities at large.

Respect – An Important Affect in East Asian Learners

Another important but hitherto not well-understood affect of East Asian learners is respect toward teachers. In [Chapter 3](#), I discussed the basic idea of respect in Chinese learners. I focus here on the emotionality of respect that Asian learners may experience during learning. Elsewhere I have reviewed research on respect in the West and in East Asia and advanced the theoretical distinction between two kinds of respect – *ought-respect* and *affect-respect* – that may exist in both the West and in East Asia.⁴⁷ Ought-respect refers to the kind of respect everyone deserves based on political, moral, and legal considerations. As such, ought-respect is not generated in a specific social context or relationship because it is for everyone. This kind of respect does not vary based on temporal or contextual particularities that underlie the occurrences of emotions. Given that it is tied to a rights-based moral principle and mandated by law, and it is not person- or relationship-specific, ought-respect is unlikely to be a prototypical emotion, but a more reason-based social, moral, and attitudinal construct. Research indicates that ought-respect may be more prevalent in the West than in Asia.

Quite differently, affect-respect is mostly an emotion that is generated in a specific social context or relationship. This kind of respect occurs when an individual genuinely recognizes, acknowledges, and admires another for his or her merit, achievement, moral qualities, and/or status/position/role/power. Affect-respect necessarily rests on the awareness that the self is either of lesser quality than or shares a similar quality with the other. This

self-awareness, particularly of the gap between oneself and the other, necessarily presupposes that the self values and desires the qualities of the other. The realization that one values/desires the quality, which the self should and can acquire but has not yet achieved, may be the very foundation of affect-respect.

Affect-respect may have important and positive implications for the self. First, it may be a key part of the process of finding role models. A role model is necessarily someone whom the self admires and desires to emulate, and it is one positive possible self.⁴⁸ When a person has identified a role model, that person has a clear, concrete, tangible, real human figure in mind to seek to emulate. The fact that a person is identified as a role model for the self indicates that the self has some understanding of the basic quality, merit, and achievement that the role model has. The identification of a role model also indicates at least some self-awareness of the *discrepancy* between the self and the role model and quite possibly also awareness of ways to narrow this discrepancy. Second, each time the self is made aware of the role model, the self may experience affect-respect, a highly positive emotion that also makes the self feel good about him- or herself, as discussed earlier. Finally, affect-respect may generate strong motivation for behavior that propels the self toward acquiring the qualities that the respected person possesses. In sum, feeling affect-respect for a person may make the self eventually become such a person. This may be called the “self-Pygmalion process” (named after the sculptor in Greek mythology whose sculpture came to life). Research shows that affect-respect may be more widely experienced by Asian people because their cultures emphasize learning from exemplary models.

Research on who receives affect-respect in the West found four categories of people: (1) those displaying moral and virtuous qualities (e.g., honest, trustworthy, just), (2) those who possess admirable talents/skills, (3) those who are sensitive toward others (e.g., considerate, accepting others, understanding, and empathic), and (4) members of a respect-worthy social category.⁴⁹ A study I conducted on Chinese conceptions of respect found two additional categories of people who receive affect-respect: (1) parents/elders/kin and (2) teachers/mentors/scholars.⁵⁰

In terms of learning, the last category is of particular relevance to Chinese learners. Respect for teachers/mentors/scholars indicates that one has role models in the classroom to draw on. In addition, these role models are charged to teach the students. One needs to emulate the models and to self-improve continuously. At the same time, one needs to remain humble and receptive to teaching of these respected learning models. Hence, respect as

an affect toward teachers is highly positive for Chinese learners because it may likely help them become like their teachers who, after all, are supposed to embody the Confucian image of self-perfection through learning.

Having clarified the meaning of Chinese learners' respect toward their teachers, I hope to say a few words on learners' affect under the influence of the Asian so-called authoritarian teachers. There is no doubt that how teachers conduct themselves in their instruction and interactions with students can directly impact children's affective experience. If Chinese teachers were truly authoritarian, then Chinese children should feel fear, instead of respect, for teachers.⁵¹ Unfortunately, there is scarce research on students' affective responses to Asian authoritarian teachers. Nevertheless, available research may hint at unexpected affective experience when Chinese learners view their supposedly "authoritarian" teachers.

Hsueh and colleagues⁵² asked European-American and Chinese elementary school and middle school children to indicate, from the following list, the reasons for which they might show respect toward teachers:

- Do what your teacher tells you to do (obedience)
- Work hard on your schoolwork (learning virtues)
- Help your teacher when she needs help (social approval)
- Don't cause trouble in class (avoidance of punishment)
- Treat your teacher like you would treat your parent (parent-teacher similarity).

These reasons were derived from interviews conducted with open-ended questions to which similarly aged children from both cultures responded. The research team found that similar numbers of children of the two groups – but in each instance representing the minority of children in their respective group – chose social approval, avoidance of punishment, and parent-teacher similarity. At the same time, obedience was chosen by significantly more European-American children (37 percent), whereas learning virtues were chosen by the smallest number of European-American children (8 percent). Chinese children showed the opposite pattern; significantly more of them (33.4 percent) chose learning virtues whereas the smallest number chose obedience (6 percent). These findings suggest that for Chinese children, showing respect for teachers is tied to how they themselves are motivated to learn with their learning virtues. For European-American children, on the other hand, respect for teachers is more about following the rules of authority, which is not closely tied to personal effort as applied to learning itself. These findings provide support that a significant number of East Asian learners' respect for teachers is primarily not a

result of obedience, seeking teacher approval, and avoidance of punishment (fear), but of virtue-oriented learning.

Post-Learning

Because learning is a continuous process throughout life, Chinese learners may not put as much emphasis on the dichotomy of success versus failure of a particular learning task or activity. In other words, their affective responses may not zero in on the impact of success or failure in any given learning situation. This tendency of theirs may also stem from Asian Taoist worldview that there are no absolutes, fixed opposites, or true dichotomies in the world.⁵³ One state can change into the other, and the whole world is in constant flux. Human learning is no exception. If one does not learn well in one point of time on one task, it does not mean that that person will not learn well the next time. However, a learner cannot sit there, waiting for miracles to change his or her fate. Instead, the learner needs to understand what he or she did not know or did not do well and to find ways to change his or her learning approach. Likewise, if one learns well at one point in time and on one task, this does not mean that one will be guaranteed to do as well the next time. Again, one needs to continue one's effort and remain humble to seek further learning regardless of how well one learns at any given moment.

In fact, this is how many respondents of my model learner study responded to the question of how the learner would learn when facing failure or when achieving highly. As a result, their affective responses to this ongoing learning perspective may be less dramatically high for good learning and dramatically low for poor learning as discussed previously. The following are excerpts on failure (e.g., not getting a good grade on an exam or receiving unfavorable remarks from a teacher) that suggest the general response pattern:

He would not be discouraged at all. On the contrary, he would be more invigorated and defeat difficulties eventually. He believes that failure is not to be feared. One needs only to learn from one's mistakes, and success is guaranteed.

First, she would feel dejected for a short while. But then she would start looking for the cause of the failure by reflection. She does this because she thinks that nothing about falling down itself is a big deal; the key is that one can stand up where one has fallen down before.

In the face of failure, he would think cool-headedly. Then he would know what to do next. He believes that only after reflection, one would not act on undue impulses. It's not necessary to be depressed about one failing exam.

For high achievement, these responses complement their expressions on failure:

He would continue to study hard, aiming at the next success because he knows one-time success is only a mark on the road, but not the end of the whole course of learning.

He would not be arrogant; instead he would have the right attitude. Achievement can only say something about one's past, and cannot indicate anything about one's future. If one is complacent about one-time success and stops making progress, one would fall backwards.

To obtain direct affective responses, I asked Chinese and European-American college students in the same study to describe how their model learners would feel emotionally about being knowledgeable as a general sense of learning achievement. Forty two percent of Chinese (and 62 percent European-American) respondents acknowledged that their model learners would feel generally happy and fulfilled (including other similar positive affects such as joyful, excited, satisfied, and pleased). However, only 22 percent of Chinese (but 53 percent of European-American, more than twice as many) respondents mentioned pride as the other distinct affect. In addition, 28 percent of Chinese (compared to only 9 percent of European-American – three times fewer than Chinese) respondents also expressed humility/calmness in the face of being knowledgeable and well-learned. Finally, 28 percent of Chinese (but only 2 percent of European-American) respondents stated that their model learners were not satisfied with their achievement and would be motivated to learn more.

When not being knowledgeable and not well-learned, 30 percent of Chinese (19 percent of European-American) respondents mentioned shame/guilt, but these Chinese respondents also included an expression of self-reproach. In comparison, no European-American respondents mentioned self-reproach. Instead, 47 percent of them (but no Chinese respondents) acknowledged frustration, discouragement, disappointment, and anger. However, 27 percent of them – a higher number than European-American respondents (19 percent) – wrote about these model learners feeling sadness and depression. Nevertheless, their sadness/depression did not appear to be related to a sense of inferiority and low self-esteem, because no one mentioned this kind of affect (but 19 percent of European-American respondents describe such feelings). Instead, 40 percent of them (but 28 percent of European-American respondents) wrote that these learners were motivated to learn more in order to make up for their inadequacies.

Lower Pride but Higher Humility

At this point, it is important to discuss two significant but related affects – pride and humility – that are experienced by East Asian learners. For East Asians, pride is a controversial emotion in empirical research, and humility as a virtue has been promoted in East Asia for millennia, although for some reason it has garnered little research attention. Because of the peculiar statuses of these two affects in research, I hope to discuss them together in order to shed some analytical light on these important affects in East Asian learners.

As noted in the section on Western learners, pride is a highly positive affect. Because the self is centrally implicated, pride is also regarded as a positive self-conscious emotion.⁵⁴ Pride arises when a person accomplishes a task of some difficulty or challenge. It could be any task or performance that requires a comparably significant level of ability/competence/skill/knowledge, artistic or athletic talent or other physical prowess, quality of work, and standards of judgment or evaluation. For example, a dancer feels pride when she wins a competition, or simply is admired by others, or a child feels pride when he finally learns how to tie his or her own shoelaces. Even though individuals can self-impose any level of competence or standard of performance, their awareness of these levels and standards points to the sociocultural origin of such levels and standards, regardless of whether others are watching, or whether a particular level or standard is internalized. Thus, pride is unlikely to occur without some sort of social comparison – that is, an awareness of how one measures up to others in achievement and performance of similar tasks/skills. Because learning achievement, particularly in the formal setting, is directly evaluated based on social comparison, learners feel pride when they achieve well, in comparison with others.⁵⁵

In the West, the opposite of pride is shame/embarrassment/inferiority/low self-esteem/low self-worth. Shame in the West is mostly a negative emotion, a disgrace that is believed to be harmful to people and is to be rid of. By contrast, in Confucian persuasion, feeling shame is regarded as a moral guide or inner voice that people need to exercise in order to examine their own wrongdoing as well as to summon their courage to admit wrong on the one hand and to desire to self-improve on the other. Shame therefore is one of the four cardinal Confucian moral sensibilities to be developed in people. These moral principles are carved on the Boston Chinatown Gate.⁵⁶ Michael Lewis's extensive research has demonstrated that pride and shame in the West are likely to be the opposite, particularly in individuals who feel globally low self-worth (that has presumably developed as a result of

repeated failure). Such Western individuals show stronger pride when they succeed in a task, but they also show higher levels of shame when they fail a task.⁵⁷

Pride in East Asian learners does not mean the same and is not experienced in the same way. First, there is no equivalent Chinese term into which the English term *pride* can be translated as a wholly positive term. Based on an empirical procedure I used to translate the English and Chinese terms, the closest term is *jiao-ao* (驕傲).⁵⁸ Accordingly, thirteen of fourteen (93 percent) fully bilingual and college-educated people (either born/raised or having spent at least ten years in the United States) translated the English *pride* or *feeling proud* into *jiao-ao*, with only one person translating it into the Chinese term *zihao* (自豪) (a related term that is probably better captured in the English term *honor* rather than *pride*). But 31 percent among these translators stated that *jiao-ao* also has a negative connotation of *arrogant* and *conceited*. Then another group of eighteen of twenty (90 percent) bilingual people from similar backgrounds translated the Chinese *jiao-ao* into English *pride/proud*. Out of these eighteen, two people translated *jiao-ao* as *stuck-up*, *overconfident*, *boastful*, *conceited*, and *arrogant*, and seven additional people (nine overall, or 45 percent of the entire group) mentioned that *jiao-ao* has a negative connotation indicating arrogance in general. They stated that which connotation to use depends on the context. These thirty-four bilingual people's translations led to the conclusion that *jiao-ao* and *pride* are the closest equivalent. It is also clear that *jiao-ao* and *pride* have very different meanings, even though they may share some core positive meaning.

Second, other empirical research documents that pride in Asian people is a paradoxical emotion.⁵⁹ This means that it is both positive and negative. For example, Chinese, compared to their European-American counterparts, were found less likely to judge pride as an emotion that they would like to experience.⁶⁰ By using a questionnaire method with college students, Deborah Stipek found that Chinese, unlike their European-American peers (who would feel and express pride for themselves), would feel pride more readily when their family members achieve well (e.g., getting into a prestigious university) than when they *themselves* achieve well.⁶¹ Chinese respondents revealed that pride should only be experienced when the achievement benefits others – a research result that others have encountered as well. Other researchers used the experience sampling method to collect randomly sampled real emotional experiences for a week and found that Chinese and Taiwanese rated pride less desirable and appropriate than European-Americans and Australians. Moreover, although Asian

Americans and Japanese experienced pride as a positive emotion, they (but not European-Americans) also felt a host of unpleasant emotions (guilt, irritation, sadness, and worry) when they experienced pride. Statistical analysis shows that pride has both positive and negative valences (in factor loading).⁶² Finally, my colleague and I conducted a study on how preschool children perceive their achieving peers. We found that Chinese children as young as five expressed what we called an “arrogance concern” about high achievers, believing that they might grow too proud of themselves to continue to self-improve. This tendency was significantly more prevalent among Chinese children than among their European-American peers.⁶³

Further explication of the mixed nature of pride in East Asian learning is warranted. As my translation procedure and Stipek’s research indicate, this double-valenced affect is context-specific. When an East Asian experiences good learning, for example, his or her initial response is likely to be positive – that is, similar to the pride of European-Americans. However, this first appraisal and related affective experience may be short-lived.⁶⁴ What ensues is the self-reflection with a preventive focus owing to the cultural orientation that influences how people regulate their own emotions.⁶⁵ The actual process may be something like the following: “I did it! I am happy that I worked hard at it and that I was able to succeed. But beware, don’t be too full of yourself; there is more to achieve. If I express my happiness openly and publicly, people may think that I am arrogant. Besides, showing pride publicly will make others feel bad about not doing so well. So I should stay humble. It’s good for me and for others.” However, if the person feels pride as a result of a collective achievement, the negative feeling may not occur, even though Chinese people may still have preventive feelings to some extent.⁶⁶ For example, people may still say to each other: “Okay, our Olympic math team did well, but they need to work harder to achieve more.”

It would be erroneous to assume that this negative valence of pride is debilitating and harmful to East Asian learners. Recent research documents that as a style of their self-regulation in life, East Asians tend to focus more on what has been termed as “prevention.” Prevention focus serves to warn oneself against potential mistakes and wrongdoing in order to avoid such actions and consequences (instead of promotion focus on the positive gains and achievement).⁶⁷ Recent research shows that, compared to Westerners, Chinese people are more prevention-focused.⁶⁸ People with either focus can feel very positive about their style. Thus, the negative side of pride may serve Chinese learners well in their effort to strive to fulfill their moral and

social duties. The duality of pride in East Asians compliments rather than contradicts.

The opposite of pride in Chinese people is humility, not shame as may be the case in the West. In general, humility is regarded as a disposition, an enduring quality of a person, as Tangney and others have theorized recently.⁶⁹ This dispositional view may be quite accurate. However, because in East Asia humility is the opposite of the clear self-conscious emotion that is pride, there may also be an affective component yet to be studied in humility. As an affect, individuals may experience humble feelings as they engage in learning (and other domains of life), particularly in their responses to learning outcomes.

Humility has been an integral part of Confucian teaching since ancient times. It appears to be more highly valued in Asia than in the West, although there is very little research on the subject. Humility is highly valued and actively promoted as a personal quality as well as an affective expression in East Asia. Recent research on Western notions of humility documents some positive views of humility in people who are religious or are involved in close relationships; however, it is evident that humility is not desirable in leaders and entertainers.⁷⁰ Contrary to the West, humility in the Confucian persuasion has never been conceived of as a personal weakness or lowly self-regard, but only as a strength one must have if one desires to self-cultivate.⁷¹ In Chinese Taoist philosophy, the notion of fullness (滿) is also conceived of as a psychological dynamic in a person (or nature) that turns against oneself, impeding the self from achieving one's full humanity and greatness.⁷² Both Confucian and Taoist schools of thought share the view that having a full sense of self (e.g., knowing all, being perfect, having all wealth, controlling all) is one true personal weakness (similar to the noted problems of narcissism in the West⁷³). Therefore, self's fullness (自滿) is a serious impediment in learning.

The antidote against self's fullness is humility. This personal strength is not military force, wealth, dominant personality, or even persuasive power, but *inner* strength that interestingly results in a gentle, soft, and nonaggressive style.⁷⁴ Everyone is believed to possess this potential. Once developed, such strength is also believed to be inexhaustible and unbendable by any external force, enabling the person to seek self-improvement with tenacity and persistence. People with such inner strength can truly examine themselves, see their own inadequacies, and seek ways to self-improve. This kind of inner strength and agency has nothing to do with low self-regard, because the power in humility lies in the belief that the self has the capacity

to grow and needs to grow. It generates hope, optimism, and motivation for reflective personal striving.

Humility in East Asia is especially desired and revered in the domain of learning. Most learning is accompanied by achievement; individuals who achieve well are believed particularly vulnerable to an inflated sense of self. Because learning in Confucian thought is not just academic but moral and social for life, humility is regarded as the single most important means to guard oneself against falling prey to arrogance and conceitedness after high achievement. This emphasis on humility has also been noted recently by Western scholars who attempt to address the neglected research on humility in the West. Accordingly, humility is characterized as:

- an ability to acknowledge one's mistakes, imperfections, gaps in knowledge, and limitations;
- keeping one's abilities and accomplishments – one's place in the world – in perspective;
- leaving oneself more open to learn from others.⁷⁵

Research indeed shows this Asian tendency vis-à-vis one's own high achievement as well as others' attitude toward individuals of high achievement. In my model learner study, respondents were asked to describe how their model learners would respond to high achievement. Fifty four percent of them acknowledged humility (in comparison, 16 percent of European-American respondents did so). Only 5 percent acknowledged feeling proud. In fact, 22 percent (but no European-American respondent) specifically noted that their model learners would not feel proud (不驕傲/不自滿) despite their happy feelings. In addition, when asked how their model learners would act for not understanding learning materials, 62 percent of Chinese respondents wrote that they would seek others' teaching humbly (虛心請教); in comparison, only 10 percent of European-American respondents mentioned a similar behavior. More evidence comes from my study examining Chinese and European-American preschool children's perceptions of achieving peers. We found significantly more expressions among Chinese children about their need to emulate the learning models so that they can learn from the high achievers. By contrast, European-American children revealed significantly more social isolation and rejection toward high achievers.⁷⁶ Research in general psychology that has repeatedly found the so-called modesty bias among East Asians but self-enhancing bias among Western people⁷⁷ supports the idea that East Asians value and express more humility in learning (as well as across other domains of life).⁷⁸

The aforementioned review of research on East Asian learners' affect also provides a general picture. Prior to learning, their affect may be less driven by curiosity about and personal interest in a given subject or topic, and more by a longer-term goal, a will to establish for life-long dedication. Affects such as commitment, dedication, and passion matter more than situationally generated affects such as enjoyment and excitement. During learning, they show less oscillation between high and low arousal of affect (i.e., neither highly excited nor strongly frustrated). Instead, their attention seems to be geared toward how to move along with their learning toward their longer-term goals. The predominant affects are those learning virtues of self-exertion, diligence, endurance of hardship, perseverance, and concentration. A significant affect among East Asians is that they experience affect-respect toward teachers who not only are regarded as authority for teaching, but also viewed as role models for students to emulate. East Asian learners' respect toward their teachers appears not to stem from fear of the commonly labeled teacher authoritarianism, but a sense of the shared common goal of learning by exercising their virtues. After good learning, East Asian learners feel happy, as their European-American peers do. After poor learning, they feel shame/guilt and self-reproach; they also feel sad/depressed (to a lesser extent than European-American learners). Nevertheless, they seem to gravitate toward a less extreme affective state for either learning outcome. Furthermore, unlike their European-American counterparts, they tend to feel little pride because pride is a sign of one's complacency, which their cultures discourage. Such fullness of the self is regarded as a hindrance to their continuous self-striving through learning. Pride is discouraged, whereas humility is valued and encouraged. Humility as both an inner personal strength and an affective response, particularly to high achievement, is believed to be important in guiding the learners in learning.

NOTES

1. See note 66 to Chapter 3.
2. See Davidson, N., Scherer, K., & Goldsmith, H. (Eds.) (2003). *Handbook of affective science*. New York: Oxford University Press for basic descriptions of human emotions.
3. See note 67 to Chapter 3.
4. Fischer, K. W., & Tangney, J. P. (1995). Self-conscious emotions and the affect revolution: Framework and overview. In J. P. Tangney & K. W. Fischer (Eds.), *Self-conscious emotions: The psychology of shame, guilt, embarrassment, and pride* (pp. 3–22). New York: Guilford.

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6. See Damasio, A. (2005). *Descartes' error: Emotion, reason, and the human brain*. New York: Penguin; note 66 to Chapter 3; and note 4 to this chapter for research on the inseparability between cognition and affect.
7. See note 10 to Chapter 4.
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10. See the second reference in note 8 to this chapter.
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17. See Godes, O. (2009). *The effects of utility value on achievement behavior of two cultures*. Unpublished doctoral dissertation, University of Wisconsin, Madison for her research on the different motivational patterns of European-American and Asian students.
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- Science and Practice*, 2(3), 209–239. Also see Thomaes, S., Reijntjes, A., de Castro, B. O., & Bushman, B. J. (2009). Reality bites-or does it? Realistic self-views buffer negative mood following social threat. *Psychological Science*, 3(2), 1–2 for recent research showing that both inflated and deflated sense of self is maladaptive for people's coping with real negative social feedback. This means that a sense of self that is close to reality is more desirable.
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 31. Although the Western child may appear to have come up with the idea on his own, the inspiration is unlikely the child's own, but rather from the common discourse in Western culture about the value of treating animals with humanity. The child is the one who *endorses* and therefore internalizes an otherwise cultural idea as his own, which is the essence of the sociocultural origin of Vygotsky's developmental theory.
 32. See the last reference in note 31 to Chapter 3; and the third reference in note 34 to Chapter 4.
 33. See note 54 to Chapter 3.
 34. See Bandura, A., & Schunk, D. (1981). Cultivating competence, self-efficacy, and intrinsic interest through proximal self-motivation. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 41, 586–598 for their concepts of proximal versus distal goals in learning.
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 39. See the last reference in note 9 to Chapter 3.
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free time: *Juku*, *Bukatsu*, and government efforts to create more meaningful leisure. In S. Verma & R. Larson (Eds.), *Examining adolescent leisure time across cultures: developmental opportunities and risks* (New Directions for Child and Adolescent Development, No. 99). San Francisco: Jossey-Bass for examples of criticisms of Asian schooling.

41. See the second reference in note 40 to this chapter.
42. See the second reference in note 23 to Chapter 3.
43. See Tsai, J. L., Knutson, B., & Fung, H. H. (2006). Cultural variation in affect valuation. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 90(2), 288–307 for empirical evidence that Chinese prefer less high-arousal positive affect (excitement) but more low-arousal positive affect (calm) than European Americans.
44. d'Ailly, H. (2003). Children's autonomy and perceived control in learning: A model of motivation and achievement in Taiwan. *Journal of Educational Psychology*, 95(1), 84–96, p. 94.
45. See note 50 to Chapter 3.
46. Vansteenkiste, M., Zhou, M.-M., Lens, W., & Soenens, B. (2005). Experiences of autonomy and control among Chinese learners: Vitalizing or immobilizing? *Journal of Educational Psychology*, 97(3), 468–483.
47. See the reference in note 47 to Chapter 2.
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50. See note 47 to Chapter 2.
51. Additional discussion can be found in Chapter 3.
52. Hsueh, Y., Zhou, Z.-K., Cohen, R., Hundley, R. J., & Deptula, D. P. (2005). Knowing and showing respect: Chinese and U.S. children's understanding of respect and its association to their friendships. *Journal of Psychology in Chinese Societies*, 6(2), 89–120.
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55. Lewis, M. (2007). Self-conscious emotional development. In J. L. Tracy, R. W. Robins, & J. P. Tangney (Eds.), *The self-conscious emotions: Theory and research* (pp. 134–152). New York: Guilford.
56. See the first reference in note 88 to Chapter 3.
57. Lewis, M., & Wolan-Sullivan, M. (2005). The development of self-conscious emotions. In A. Elliot & C. S. Dweck (Eds.), *Handbook of competence and motivation* (pp. 185–201). New York: Guilford.
58. Li, J., Fung, H., Liang, C.-H., Resch, J., & Luo, L. (2009). Is the glass half-empty or half-full? Emotional responses to children's learning among European American and Taiwanese parents. Manuscript under review.

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61. See the second reference in note 84 to Chapter 3.
62. See the first and third references in note 59 to this chapter.
63. See the second reference in note 6 to Chapter 3.
64. See the first reference in note 61 to Chapter 3 for profiles of model learners who feel either a brief duration of happiness or do not make a big deal of high achievement. Instead, they warn themselves against arrogance and strive to focus on further learning.
65. Ayduk, O., May, D., Downey, G., & Higgins, E. T. (2003). Tactical differences in coping with rejection sensitivity: The role of prevention pride. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 29(4), 435–448; and Grant, H., & Higgins, E. T. (2003). Optimism, promotion pride, and prevention pride as predictors of quality of life. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 29(12), 1521–1523.
66. See the first and third references in note 59 to this chapter.
67. See note 65 to this chapter.
68. Lee, A. Y., Aaker, J. L., & Gardner, W. L. (2000). The pleasures and pains of distinct self-construals: The role of interdependence in regulatory focus. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 78(6), 1122–1134.
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70. See the third reference in note 82 to Chapter 3.
71. See note 5 to Chapter 2.
72. See reference in note 74 to Chapter 2.
73. See the third reference in note 82 to Chapter 3.
74. In sharp contrast to the Western view, humility is strongly desirable in leaders at any level in any organization. For example, the Yellow Emperor (c. 2718–2597, legend has it; he lived 121 years), the acknowledged legendary chieftain of tribes who united China, is known not only for his achievement of uniting Chinese tribes, but also for his humble leadership style. He is said to have created an effective and innovative administrative system and many inventions of technology such as the lunar calendar, medicine, and twelve-tone music. But he also taught people how to sow and how to harvest by personally working in the fields (also clearly symbolizing the virtue of diligence and endurance of hardship). Throughout history, leaders who were admired by people were those

who displayed humility in spite of their great power and achievements. Current Asian political leaders that win support from people seem to show this quality as well. Chinese premier Wen Jiabao is a prime example. Similarly, Ma Ying-jeou, the president of Taiwan, along with other Asian leaders, also conveys an unequivocal sense of humility in his style.

75. See the second reference in note 82 to Chapter 3, pp. 73–74.
76. See the second reference in note 6 to Chapter 3, and Li, J. (2005). Mind or virtue: Western and Chinese beliefs about learning. *Current Directions in Psychological Science*, 14(4), 190–194.
77. Heine, S. J., Lehman, D. R., Markus, H. R., & Kitayama, S. (1999). Is there a universal need for positive self-regard? *Psychological Review*, 106, 766–794. June Tangney and others distinguish humility from modesty by pointing out that humility is a personal inner strength whereas modesty is more about external aspects such as clothing and gender-related behavior (e.g., female modesty, see the third reference in note 82 to Chapter 3). However, research on Asian modesty bias versus Western self-enhancing bias uses the two terms interchangeably.
78. Because so little attention has been paid to the construct of humility, research trying to measure low self-esteem in Asian learners needs to take the notion of humility into consideration, distinguishing true low self-esteem from humility as distinguished by Tangney and others. It has been a consistent finding that Asian learners rank low on self-esteem measures despite their high achievement. For example, in the 2006 PISA international education assessment, East Asian students had low self-esteem in both math and science (South Korea ranked thirty-second in mathematics and twenty-first in science; Japan ranked thirty-fourth and sixteenth, respectively; and Taiwan ranked thirtieth and eighteenth, respectively). In contrast, U.S. students scored highest on self-esteem for science and fourth in math. Yet, their achievement in TIMSS was nineteenth in math and eighteenth in science, and in 2006, PISA ranked them fourteenth in science, fifteenth in reading, and nineteenth in math (see the first reference in note 7 to Chapter 3 for a more detailed discussion on the data). In light of the important distinction between humility and true low self-esteem, I urge researchers to rethink their measures of self-esteem intended for East Asian students, which may have mistaken a strength for a weakness, thus producing these puzzling results about East Asian students.